

Birds

The Red Kite *Milvus milvus* of the family *Accipitridae* along with other raptors such as eagles, buzzards and harriers

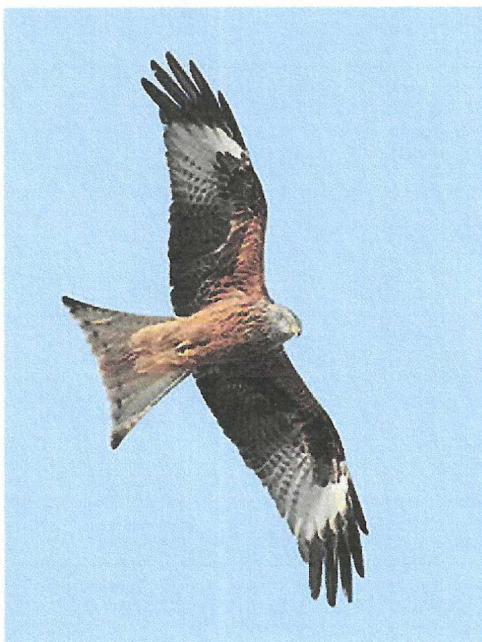


Easily recognisable high in the sky



with its deeply forked-tail which rotates at different angles to steer

and its slender wings, flat or arched, the Red Kite is strikingly elegant in its flight.



Its rufous or rust-red colour makes it unmistakable.

The juveniles have a slightly shallower tail fork and are more sandy-coloured.

Has a soft piping call, weaker, more feeble than the buzzard's.

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Usually Red Kites start breeding when they are 2-years-old.



The nest is normally built in the fork of a large tree and they do sometimes use their last year's nest. The nests vary in size and can become large when the same nest is used for several seasons.



The pair share the building – the male brings the twigs and the female places them – lined with grass and if available sheep's wool.

The Telegraph reported in June 2016 that *Rare birds of prey have been caught stealing the underwear of skinny dippers at a popular wild swimming spot in a Highland glen. The red kites have taken pants and socks to line their nest, including designer brands such as Armani, which have helped keep four chicks warm this summer.*

Shakespeare also warned: "*When the kite builds, look to your lesser linen*".

One to 3 eggs, matt-white with red-brown spots, are laid at 3-day intervals and incubated by the female, who gets time off for her own feeding, for about a month. Both parents care for the chicks. The eggs are about 57 mm x 45 mm.



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They hunt over open terrain, typically old woods mixed with open fields, and live on small rodents, smaller birds, insects but also take dead animals and refuse, stealing prey from other birds, eg rooks and crows, on the way.

They have been known to steal food from people as well like gulls.



A Red Kite problem occurs on Otmoor RSPB Reserve when the lapwings lay their eggs - eggs which are food for kites' families. RSPB are providing free meals on raised tables as a distraction. This diversionary tactic hopefully reduces the predation of wader chicks and protects the lapwing numbers.

The number of Red Kites in the UK was reduced to 10 pairs, all in south Wales, before a reintroduction programme was established. The ones we see over the field, and also in the thermals over the M40, were reintroduced to the Chilterns in 1989 and at the same time others were reintroduced in northern Scotland. Since then they have been reintroduced to the Borders and also to Durham and Northumberland and in 2010 to Grizedale in Cumbria.

Birds

Way back in history

- a Red Kite is mentioned in Chaucer's *The Knight's Tale*.
- In Tudor times bounties could be paid for their carcasses.
- Shakespeare's King Lear called his daughter, Goneril, a *detested kite*
- In Scotland James II decreed that they should be *killed wherever possible*
- But in England and Wales they remained a protected species.

However, in January 2006 in the Independent, a headline read:
Shakespeare's Red Kite returns to London after an absence of 150 years
It had once been as much a London bird as the ravens in the tower of London, in Shakespeare's words "*The city of kites and crows*".

But they kept the streets clean of carrion and rubbish until improved public hygiene and waste-disposal did away with Londoners' need for them and they became extinct as a breeding bird – the last sighting on London streets had been in 1859.



We know that the first recorded instance of a toy kite attached to a string and flown in the air dates from the 17th century.

Text/facts from RSPB. Lars Jonsson's *Birds of Europe*, Wikipedia and the internet

Risinghurst and Sandhills Parish Council April 2019 Autumn

www.risinghurstsandhillsparishcouncil.com